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Ahead of Olympics, legislators seeks $2B for LA Metro, other transit agencies

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With Los Angeles gearing up to host FIFA World Cup matches in 2026 and the Olympics in 2028 — and with LA Metro expected to play a major role in shuttling people to and from events — one Southern California legislator is co-leading an effort to direct more state funds to public transit agencies to keep them from buckling under financial pressures.

Assemblymember Mark González, D-Los Angeles, along with state Sen. Jesse Arreguín, D-Berkeley, sent letters to legislative leaders in March, asking for $2 billion in flexible funding over the next two fiscal years to address transit agencies' operating shortfalls.

Although this set-aside of dollars was not included in Gov. Gavin Newsom's revised budget proposal that recently came out, budget negotiations between the governor and legislature have only started in earnest.

"We still intend on pursuing this request through the legislature," Stefan Elgstrand, press secretary for Arreguín, said in an email. He noted that Senate Budget Committee Chair Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, has expressed support for additional funding for transit.

The $2 billion would be split between LA Metro, Bay Area Rapid Transit and other public transit systems in the state and would allow transit operators to proceed with capital projects while they work on long-term revenue streams, according to the letters to legislative leaders.

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Many public transit agencies haven't fully recovered since the COVID-19 pandemic and have reduced routes, service frequency and operating hours, as well as deferred maintenance or paused capital projects, the letters said.

In addition, millions of visitors will rely on public transit during the World Cup and Olympic and Paralympic Games, and investments in rail, bus lines and other transit-related infrastructure are needed to ensure safety, reliability and efficiency in the transit systems during these events, say those advocating for more transit dollars.

"When Los Angeles committed to a car-free Olympics, it pledged to reduce congestion, advance climate goals and leave lasting infrastructure benefits. However, significant funding gaps remain, and uncertainty surrounds federal funding approval. We must act now to uphold this commitment and demonstrate California's leadership on the global stage," said the letter that González and 10 of his colleagues in the Assembly signed.

In addition, the letter said "communities most dependent on transit cannot afford service reductions, and failure to prepare for global events is not an option."

Their letter was addressed to Assembly Budget Committee Chair Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, and Assemblymember Steve Bennett, D-Ventura, who chairs the budget subcommittee that deals with transportation.

A similar letter, signed by Arreguín and two other senators, was sent to Senate President Pro Tem Mike McGuire, D-North Coast, Wiener and Sen. Laura Richardson, D-San Pedro, who serves on the Senate budget and transportation committees and the Senate Special Committee on International Sporting Events.

L.A. County Supervisor and LA Metro board Chair Janice Hahn said the transit agency will need support from both the state and federal government as the greater L.A. area prepares to host major global sporting events.

"Metro is going to be on the world stage with the World Cup and the Olympic and Paralympic Games, and we have a lot of work to do to make sure we are ready to get visitors, spectators and residents where they need to go quickly, conveniently and safely," she said.

It's unclear how much of the $2 billion being requested would go specifically to LA Metro.

LA Metro CEO Stephanie Wiggins, in a letter to legislative leaders in March, said the money should be equitably distributed.

Wiggins also wrote that LA Metro — whose current fiscal year's budget is about $9 billion — is facing a $2.3 billion deficit through 2030 despite year-over-year growth in ridership since the pandemic.

"Overall, we are at 90% of our pre-pandemic numbers, and on Sundays, we have even exceeded our 2019 ridership," said Wiggins, who attributed the growth in ridership to the agency's focus on safety, reliability, equity and accessibility.

"However," Wiggins continued, "Metro is still facing significant financial challenges."

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